

Exodus 38:8

And he made the laver of brass, and the foot of it of brass, of the lookingglasses of the women assembling, which **assembled at the door of the tabernacle of the congregation**.

1 Samuel 2:22

Now Eli was very old, and heard all that his sons did unto all Israel; and how they lay with the women that **assembled at the door of the tabernacle of the congregation**.

These woman are only mentioned two times in the entire Bible. At first glance it appears that we aren't given much information about who these woman were or what they did. However, when we carefully consider the details that we are given in light of all of scripture we can learn so much more. For example, we are told that they assembled "at the door of the tabernacle of the congregation". So the question is, where exactly is that? *PAUSE*.

DESCRIBE DIAGRAM

The phrase "door of the tabernacle of the congregation" appears 45 times in 45 verses. Let's have a look at a few of them. The first, second, third, and fourth time that this phrase appears is in **Exodus 29** which describes the process for hallowing the priests to minister to God (TURN TO **EXO 29**). *BEFORE READING EXPLAIN THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A LEVITE AND A PRIEST*. All priests are Levites but not all Levites are priests (**Lev 18**). (**Ezekiel**, Millennial kingdom; sons of Zadok the son of Eleazar the son of Aaron the son of Levi; **1Ch 6:3-8**, **Ezra 7:1-5**).

READ EXODUS 29:1,4,11

v4 (1st) the priests were able to wash nearby (**Exo 40:12**)

1. *SHOW ON DIAGRAM WHERE THE LAVER FOR WASHING WAS*

v11, 42 (2nd) Wherever this place is, it is "before the LORD". So, where is "before the LORD"?

2. First, we need to understand that "before the LORD" does not mean "before him in time" but instead it means "in front of the LORD"

3. *THEN READ EXODUS 40:34 AND EXPLAIN WHERE "BEFORE (IN FRONT OF) THE LORD" WAS*

4. *DRAW EXO 40:34 ON THE DIAGRAM ABOVE THE SANCTUARY*

5. *DRAW THE ARROW INDICATING WHAT IS BEFORE THE LORD ON THE DIAGRAM*

Now that we've established which door is the "door of the tabernacle" what about the other door? There must be a different name for it right? I'm glad you asked. READ **Exodus 27:16**, **38:18**, **Numbers 4:26**.

So now that we know where the woman were assembled there's one more small but important detail we that tells us exactly where these woman were assembled. There are 8 different words that all appear before the phrase "the door of the tabernacle of the congregation". READ THE 8 WORDS. Does anyone remember which one applies to the woman in **Exo 38:8** & **1Sa 2:22**?

unto	the door of the tabernacle of the congregation
by	
at	
to	
of	
from	
for	
before	

Now that we know exactly where the woman were assembled that then opens the door to find out who they were and what were they doing. Assuming these woman were obeying the law we can check the law and see who was permitted to regularly be in this area.

From Numbers (Numbers 18:1-7) and Leviticus we learn that no Levite nor stranger was permitted to even come close to the vessels of both the sanctuary and the altar. Unless it was a specifically commanded occasion like a sacrifice (Lev 1:1-3, 3:1,2, 12:6,7), the cleansing of a leper (Lev 14:11), or a Nazarite shaving the head of his separation (Num 6:18) non-Levites were not permitted to wander about the court of the tabernacle let alone anywhere else inside (Num 1:51). The tribes of Levi (Merari, Gershon, Kohath) were required to camp round about the entire tabernacle and part of the duty of the men was to guard it that no wrath be upon the congregation of the children of Israel (Num 1:53).

Speaking of duty, now that we know these woman necessarily had to be Levites, let's look at the duties given to only male Levites so we know what these woman were permitted to do.

1. All of the "work in the tabernacle of the congregation" was restricted to male Levites (Numbers 3:15, 4:2,3). The word work here covers a broad range of physical activities and is the exact same Hebrew word used in Exodus 20:9 "Six days shalt thou labour, and do all thy work."
 - There are even many specifics given about this work for example the sons of Kohath were strictly forbidden from using wagons, unlike the Gersonites and Merarites, and they were required to carry their burdens on their shoulders.
2. The carrying of the various parts of the tabernacle when it was transported. While the Levite males were commanded to carry all the various parts of the tabernacle divided by their families, they were not permitted to touch any holy thing. The priests covered all the holy things before the Levites picked them up. Numbers 4:4-20, 7:9.

So, if the males were the only ones permitted to perform all the physical duties of the tabernacle what was left for these female Levites to do? The simple version is anything that was permitted on the sabbath day but only permitted inside the court of the tabernacle. But, since that's very general we'll keep digging. Let's have a look at the MT Hebrew for the words "assembling" and "assembled" in Exodus 38:8.

- The Hebrew word behind "assembling" is Ha-tzov'ot which doesn't mean much until we learn that this is the same exact Hebrew word behind "host" as in "The LORD of hosts". This is a military term that tells us that this was not a casual gathering. Other English words based on the same Hebrew root are: perform, wait, warred, mustered, fight, and fought.
- The Hebrew word behind "assembled" is Asher tzava'u which means "they marshaled" or "they served a term of military-like duty".

Further enlightening the mystery of these woman is that in the Hebrew for Exodus 38:8 a specific type of Hebrew reduplication idiom is used called a "polyptoton". Polyptoton is a fancy word that means that "they used two different forms of the same root". Another type of Hebrew reduplication idiom is more easily recognized in the phrase "most holy" in Exodus 26:33 which is called a superlative. In the Hebrew it literally reads "holy of holies". Sometimes, this reduplication idiom was translated directly into the English as we can see in the phrases "King of kings" or "Song of songs". So what does this particular idiom in the Hebrew tell us about the woman in Exodus 38:8? Simply put, it identifies these woman not just as "workers" but instead as "office-holders". And in the broader context in order to be an office-holder in the tabernacle one has to be appointed or ordained to that office: specifically by God.

Now we can go full circle and put everything we've gathered into one basket and it tells us this: those woman that assembled at the threshold of the tabernacle before God were Levites that were ordained by God for spiritual warfare which is studying the word of God, prayer, and fasting. And let's not forget that those same woman sacrificed their lookingglasses (or personal mirrors) for the purpose of creating a holy vessel for the tabernacle (the brass laver).

And lastly,

In 1Sa 2:22 (along with Jer 7:12-14, and Jer 26:6) together with the archeological record at Shiloh, we learn that after the judges, the priests, and the guardians of the tabernacle had compromised themselves, Shiloh was destroyed and burned in God's judgment.